

GENDER EMBODIMENT: ELICITING CONVERSATIONS WITH PATIENTS

GENDER HEALTH SF
SF DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC HEALTH

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AGENDA

Experiences of gender dysphoria & gender incongruence

What is Gender Embodiment?

Eliciting a conversation with your patient

Surgical Considerations & Options

START WITH THE BASICS



gender dysphoria vs Gender Dysphoria

gender dysphoria is the **distress** caused by the discrepancy between one's experienced or expressed gender and one's assigned sex at birth and/or primary/secondary sex characteristics.

Gender Dysphoria (GD) a diagnostic category in the DSM-5, defined by specific sets of criteria.

gender incongruence Vs Gender Incongruence

gender incongruence is incongruence between experienced/expressed gender and assigned sex at birth, and/or physical gender characteristics.

Gender Incongruence is a diagnostic category (analogous to GD in DSM-5) proposed for ICD-11.

DYSPHORIA VS INCONGRUENCE

gender incongruence (gi) focuses on the identity itself or the state of being a different gender than assigned sex at birth, where gender dysphoria (gd) refers to the psychological distress or discomfort from the experience of incongruence.

Not all transgender people who experience incongruence feel dysphoria.

EXPERIENCES OF DYSPHORIA OR INCONGRUENCE

Personal

- "I know I'm a woman."
- "I am neither a man or a woman"

Emotional

- "I get depressed when I look in the mirror, I don't look like how I feel inside."
- "I feel anxious when I need to use the public restroom."

Physical

- "I hate my hips, they are so narrow."
- "I bind to hide my chest"

Spiritual/Existential

- "Something doesn't feel right in my body"
- "I'm not sure I fit in with my peer group, I think I'm different."

Social

- "It makes me feel unsafe to leave the house, I feel like people stare at me and I often get Sir'd."

Macro

- "I don't go to the doctor unless I absolutely have to because the front desk always calls out the wrong name."

DIFFERENTIAL DIAGNOSIS

Body Dysmorphia & Gender dysphoria are not the same thing.

- Experiencing Gender dysphoria does not mean having Body Dysmorphia.
- Body Dysmorphia is a persistent, intense focus, shame and anxiety over perceived body defects.
- Body Dysmorphia may sounds like "My body is ugly". Patients may focus on body apperance and image.
- Patients may repeatedly check the mirror, grooming or seeking reassurance.
- Both cisgender and transgender people may experience Body Dysmorphia.

EXPLORING THE SEA OF GENDER IDENTITY & EXPERIENCED INCONGRUENCE



CONTEXT MATTERS: WHY ARE WE ASKING?



To create a safe & holistic care space with our patients: build trust with our patients.



To understand embodiment goals for medical or social transition.



To explore prevenative care options.



For a patient to feel heard, seen, and affirmed.



For a patient to be given an opportunity to express their gender affirming goals and desires in a non-judgemental space.

**GENDER IS EXPERIENCED IN
THE MIND, BODY AND
THROUGH BEHAVIOR.**

TOPICS TO EXPLORE

1. Gender expression and social transition—pronouns, name, clothing.

- Tell me about your gender identity and how that has evolved for you?
- Do you have a preferred name?
- Have you thought about ways to affirm your gender expression or identity socially?
- Are there places you feel most comfortable expressing your gender identity?

TOPICS TO EXPLORE

2. Explore the impact of gender dysphoria across all psychosocial elements, including school, work, home and relationships.

- Are their places in your life such as school or work where dysphoria shows up more or less?
- Do feelings of dysphoria show up in your relationships, are there experiences in relationships where it shows up more or less?
- Are you connected to family? If yes, what does that relationship look like?

TOPICS TO EXPLORE

3. Discuss discomfort with primary/secondary sex characteristics, a strong desire to be seen or treated as another gender.

- Are you experiencing any discomfort or anxiety in your body?
- Are there specific parts or locations on your body where you feel more or less distress?
- Are there experiences that increase or decrease dysphoria?
- How do you imagine your body to be, or what changes would you make to your body if possible?

TOPICS TO EXPLORE

4. Duration of distress and historically significant feelings or expressions.

- How long have you felt distress from dysphoria in your body?
- What have been significant feelings or experiences in your recent history regarding your gender identity or expression?
- How and when do you experience gender euphoria?

GENDER AFFIRMING CARE

Gender affirming care has been deemed medically necessary treatment for individuals who experience gender dysphoria and/or gender incongruence for individuals with a diagnosis of GD or GI.

Gender affirming care is life saving treatment.

SCOPE OF GENDER AFFIRMING CARE

Gender affirming surgeries are considered reconstructive, not cosmetic.

This is because they are addressing gender dysphoria, which can improve mental health and support a patient's alignment with their authentic self.

Surgeons and insurance have a scope or range of what they consider to be gender affirming & medically necessary treatment to treat dysphoria distress.

GENDER EMBODIMENT & SURGICAL GOALS

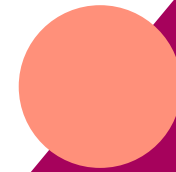


Photo: The gender spectrum project

WHAT IS GENDER EMBODIMENT?

Gender embodiment is the process through which individuals experience, express, and create gender through their physical bodies, intertwining subjective feelings with social and cultural expectations.

It is the "lived" intersectionality of how behavior, body, and appearance signify an individual's gender.



ELICITING A CONVERSATION WITH YOUR PATIENT



GENDER EMBODIMENT GOALS: ELICITING A CONVERSATION

- **Start with affirmation:** "So glad you are here to talk about xyz, I'm happy to support you with that."
- **Get consent:** "I'd like to ask some questions that will give me a better understanding of what is important to you & what information would be most helpful to share. Is that ok?"
- **Keep it open ended:** "Can you tell me how you came to decision you wanted xyz?/can you share how you came to understand that you need xyz?"
 - Follow up: "can you tell me more about what you most want to see/feel in your body after having xyz?"
- **Give space/pass the mic/assess knowledge:** "Tell me what you already know about xyz"
- **Offer info:** Can I share with you some of the kinds of gender affirming care that are available? (primary care, hormones, non-surgical procedures, surgeries)
- **Double back:** "is there anything we didn't talk about that you want me to know about your gender/about what's important to you about GAC/about the care you need?"

GENDER EMBODIMENT GOALS: GETTING SPECIFIC

- I'd love to hear more about your gender embodiment goals...
- Can we talk about how you currently relate to your body? For example are there parts of your body that make you feel uncomfortable or that you would like to change? Are there things that feel important to maintain?
- How would you like to relate to your body—example how would you like to feel, act, and express yourself in the world?

GENDER AFFIRMING SURGICAL OPTIONS

Chest	Breast augmentation
	Chest masculinization
Facial	FFS Facial Feminization Surgery
	FMS Facial Masculinization Surgery
Body	Fem contouring (lipo +fat transfer)
	Masc contouring (typically lipo only)
Genital	Orchiectomy & Vaginoplasty
	Hysterectomy/Oophorectomy/metoidioplasty/phalloplasty
Hair Restoration	Fem: Hairline lowering, thinning hair
	Masc: facial hair for beard, mustache, sideburns
Other options:	Nonbinary options for any of the above procedures, unique nonbinary techniques
	Vocal cord surgery

GENDER AFFIRMING NON-SURGICAL OPTIONS

Hair removal

Social transition—name change, clothing swaps/community closets

Support groups and community building

Fillers

Voice therapy

GENDER EMBODIMENT: CONSIDERATIONS

What do you know about is this procedure?

What questions do you have about this procedure?

Are there any changes that might occur with this procedure that you are unsure about?

Surgery comes with change, what are your hopes & expectations about the changes that will occur? what might not change?

NORMALIZE GETTING MORE INFORMATION.

IT IS TYPICAL TO HAVE QUESTIONS AND
NEED MORE INFORMATION ABOUT
SURGICAL PROCEDURES THAT YOU MAY BE
INTERESTED IN BEFORE KNOWING IF
A PROCEDURE IS RIGHT FOR YOUR
EMBODIMENT GOALS.

GATHERING INFORMATION IS A PART OF
THE PROCESS.

GENDER EMBODIMENT: SURGICAL GOALS

How will you know if a procedure is successful?

What will be the benefits of this procedure for you? What are you looking forward to?

Are there body changes that you do not want to occur with the use of hormones or a specific procedure?

Let's imagine that you complete all your procedures that you want, what is next? How do you imagine the integration between body, mind, and expression?

RESOURCING

- Gender Health SF Surgical Ed Brochures
- Gender Health SF Website
- San Francisco Health Plan contracted gender affirming surgeon websites:
 - MoZaic Care, ART Surgical, Align Surgical, Gender Confirmation Center (GCC), etc.

SURGICAL READINESS

Safe Recovery Place—stable, access to bathroom & clean water, privacy

An identifiable support network or designated support person/people

Transportation Plan

Food & Nutrition Access

Surgery is stressful (even under optimal conditions!)—Mental Health stability/support is essential

Substance use discussed with patient & support plan in place

Aftercare follow up plan with Primary Care & MH team post-surgery

PEARLS & TAKE AWAYS

Get the basics down: name, pronouns, be affirming to an individuals gender experience.

Proactively seek consultation and education.

Context Matters: Tell patients why you are asking questions and for what purpose.

Focus on someones authentic identity, expression, and embodiment experience versus traumatic or distressing events.

Reinforce an informed consent process by normalize and encouraging patients to ask question and gathering information about gender affirming surgeries as they relate to their goals.

QUESTIONS



MONTHLY GENDER CONSULTATION GROUP

EVERY SECOND TUESDAY OF THE MONTH, 11AM TO 12PM VIA TEAMS

PURPOSE: The GHSF Clinical Consultation Group provides a supportive space for clinicians, social workers, and medical providers to:

- Consult on client cases
- Discuss systemic issues and barriers to care
- Share resources and best practices
- Connect with others serving transgender and gender-expansive individuals

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MORE SERIES COMING UP FOR PRIDE MONTH!

June 17, 2026 - When the Face Reflects the Self: New Horizons in Facial Surgery

Dr. Angela Rodriguez, MD (she/her), ART Surgical

June 24, 2026 - Body Contouring with Dr. Breanna Jedrzejewski

Dr. Breanna Jedrzejewski, MD, MPH (she/her), Align Surgical Associates

July 1, 2026 - Vaginoplasty with Dr. Heidi Wittenberg

Dr. Heidi Wittenberg, MD, FPMRS (she/her), MoZaic Care Inc. & UCSF Gender Institute

CONTACT INFO

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